



**SELECTBOARD
TOWN OF WESTHAMPTON
TOWN HALL
1 SOUTH ROAD
WESTHAMPTON, MASSACHUSETTS 01027**

Minutes of October 12, 2021
Meeting held via ZOOM

The meeting convened at 6:30 p.m.

Present from Selectboard were Phil Dowling (Chair), Maureen Dempsey, Teri Anderson. Others present were Douglas Finn, Nick Langone & Rohail Aijaz (Eversource), Thomas Cleary, Sr., Thomas Cleary, Jr., Peter Ignatovich, Trzcienski's, Luis Arroyo, Liana, Robbie Armenti & Tom Martin (Board of Health), Barbara Pelissier, Susan Bronstein. Minutes taken by Cheryl Provost.

- **PUBLIC HEARING** opened at 6:30 p.m. for petition from **NSTAR Electric Company doing business as Eversource "Install one solely owned pole on Stage Road"**

Nick Langone described the project is to provide power to the public safety complex that's required for the project. A new pole installed on Southampton Road to serve the complex and make the intersection neater related to the overhead lines. Phil reported that Highway Superintendent Bill Jablonski has no issues with the location. N Langone explained the town owns the cost associated with installing the transformers, Eversource is responsible to maintain those in perpetuity. The hearing opened for questions. Clarification was made of location of pole, is on town owned right of way. No other comments/questions. Phil motioned to approve the order for pole location as submitted. Second by Maureen. Discussion ensued regarding the Standard Conditions, to be attached to the Order For Pole Location. So moved by roll call vote. Maureen-yes
Teri-yes
Phil-yes

Hearing closed at 6:38 p.m.

Department updates

- Public Safety Complex update, Phil reported project is moving ahead. The floor will be poured soon. The structural drawings from Lester Buildings is under review by architects and engineers.
- Town Property and Energy Assessment Committee, Phil reported on behalf of committee. The town hall floor is being sanded. Progress is ongoing. Reviewing insulation and heating recommendations for the elementary school. Also waiting for Eversource information on insulation of the town hall and two mini splits for the two offices.

- PUBLIC HEARING opened at 6:45 p.m. for petition from **NSTAR Electric Company doing business as Eversource and Verizon New England, Inc. “Install new jointly owned poles along Loudville Road from the intersection of Main Road to Mineral Road.”**

Rohail Aijaz described the project. Upgrading the lines will add customer reliability performance and system improvement in the future. This location was selected for upgrades because the service is below standards. Hearing opened to questions that were answered by R Aijaz. The project is improving overhead conductors. Start date of project is unknown. The petition was reviewed on screen and three pole locations clarified. Phil motioned to approve the order for pole location as submitted, with standard conditions attached. Maureen made note of the information provided on abutters notices has had discrepancies and would like Eversource to provide good information. Second by Teri. Teri added that Eversource make contact with the Tree Warden prior to cutting any trees. So moved by roll call vote:

Teri-yes

Maureen-yes

Phil-yes

Hearing closed at 7:05 p.m.

- Department updates

- Board of Health, Tom Martin reported:

-Foothills Health District

- implementing a three-year state grant for upgrades and expanded services for the district
- hiring full time health director
- hiring three part-time staff; public health nurse, office manager, and field inspector
- grant is for three years and told by Dept, of Public Health will be extended to six years; moving towards state support for regional public health services in response to Covid
- work environment for the health district is not adequate. Four employees work together in a small space at the Williamsburg Town Hall. Williamsburg building new safety complex and does not include space for health services. Long-term plans are to expand and improve office space at the town hall.

-the Board of Health discussed the need for space for health services. Questioned if adequate using space in the new Westhampton Public Safety Building for public health services, using ARPA funds is an option.

Phil spoke to ARPA funds and reported there are no decisions regarding use of ARPA funds. What the Selectboard has discussed is the possibility of completion of office space of the second floor of the safety complex. Getting a preliminary cost. There will be at least two public hearings on the expenditures of the funds.

Robbie reported there are reporting requirements with the Excellence Grant showing work completed by staff.

Phil suggested if office space is created for the district services that other towns will contribute.

Tom reported there has been discussions of paying rent and the costs would be shared by the member towns. The grant is to expand services as well as expand geographically, increase town membership.

Teri suggested the Selectboard should be the body seeking solicitations for proposed uses of ARPA funds to departments and residents. If Foothills Health District is seeking office space she recommended they have specs of what they need. Discussion ensued regarding funding options for space for public health services and reaching out to state representatives and legislatures. Teri mentioned the Hampshire County Courthouse has available space that may be available.

Teri noted that the Municipal Vulnerability Grant requires staff in-kind match. Overtime or comp time may be needed to pay staff. She recommends using ARPA funds for the match.

Susan Bronstein read the text of the American Recovery Plan Act and completed a one page summary of qualified expenditures.

- Appointment of Administrative Assistant. Phil motioned to appoint Douglas Finn as Administrative Assistant, starting training October 21-29, \$20 hourly. Taking office November 1 through June 30, 2023, provided satisfactory evaluation upon completion of probationary period. Second by Maureen. So moved by roll call vote:

Teri-yes

Maureen-yes

Phil-yes

Motion by Teri to authorize Phil to sign letter of appointment. Second by Phil. So moved by roll call vote:

Maureen-yes

Teri-yes

Phil-yes

- Website revisions removal of Contact Us links/webform job application
Cheryl reported the Contact Us link allows email through that are spam. Email filters recognize the website URL as safe so those emails are not flagged. Her recommendation is to remove the Contact Us option and to direct individuals to email addresses. Discussion ensued regarding other options to filter the emails, working with website support. Revision put on hold. Cheryl made a recommendation to add a webform job application to the website for electronic application submission. So moved.

- Halloween street closure. Teri motioned to close Stage Road from Hampshire Regional High School to North Road, North Road from the Library to Southampton Road, South Road from the Town Hall to Cemetery Road, or as recommended by the Westhampton Chief of Police for Halloween activities October 31, 6:00-8:00 p.m. Activities are being coordinated with the police

department. Second by Phil. So moved by roll call vote:

Maureen-yes

Teri-yes

Phil-yes

- Municipal Vulnerability Plan, Teri reported in the process of forming a working group for the Municipal Vulnerability Action Grant. The working group will be looking at the whole project but mainly focusing on the Resiliency Master Plan. There will be a sub-group for the Open Space and Recreation Plan, Laurie Sanders taking lead on that. Teri managing master planning portion with Phil as backup. Identifying individuals that are interested, including the original core members and board and committee members with expertise in areas such as agriculture, natural resource protection, and economic development. She recommends soliciting the public for residents interesting in participating. Notice to be posted to the website.
- Hybrid meeting electronic systems, Phil reported he researched costs of equipment to run OWL system. He has pricing for the device, screens, and software. He continues research on projectors. CARES funds will pay for the equipment and software. Discussion ensued regarding proposed uses of the system. Phil and Doug to work together to bring a proposal to next meeting.
- Correspondence reviewed:
 - MMA Annual Meeting and Trade Show, January 21&22; registration open
 - Barbara Pelissier waiting to hear from Westhampton regarding American Recovery Plan Act funds and public hearings. Phil explained public meetings will be held to seek suggestions from the public, likely in November/early December.
 - Zoning Board of Appeals decision V225, 15 North Road, approved
 - U.S. Dept. of Transportation notice of required entry-level drivers training
 - National Opioids Settlement overview

Reviewed minutes of:

September 27, 2021. Phil motioned to approve minutes as written. Second by Maureen. So moved by roll call vote:

Teri-yes

Maureen-yes

Phil-yes

Warrants were reviewed and approved by roll call vote:

Maureen-yes

Teri-yes

Phil-yes

Payroll: \$87,812.98

Vendor: \$404,061.03

Maureen reported Wade Clement approached her to report his experience with the application process for a variance. He inquired of the consultant /planner position and if a selection was made, suggesting

the board could have used some guidance with procedures. Teri made note that appropriation of \$6,000.00 is budgeted for consultant/planner. There has been no selection yet. She mentioned Douglas Finn's background in planning, and suggested Susan Bronstein and he discuss it. Douglas provided a brief background and welcomed the work.

Next meeting: 7:00 p.m., October 25, 2021

Adjourned meeting at 8:15 p.m.

Approved by vote of the Selectboard at virtual meeting held October 25, 2021.

Phil Dowling
Maureen Dempsey
Teri Anderson